17. Not Found Wanting

It was Saturday, 8 December 2018, the thirty-eighth anniversary of John Lennon's murder. Chelsea ended Manchester City's unbeaten run in the Premier League. Northampton Saints, my rugby team, defeated the Dragons 48–14 at Franklin's Gardens in the European Challenge Cup. I had a pleasant off-season lunch, with about twenty friends, and got the surprise of my life.

I'm not one of those obsessives who feel the need to check my phone every nanosecond, but for some reason I let it rest between my legs, on my chair. It was set to silent, but when it began to vibrate incessantly, I thought I'd better check to see if anything untoward had happened to my family, or the farm. It was a text from Mike Martin, my agent:

'You need to check your emails urgently … and by the way, I am not calling you Sir.'

So many thoughts rush through your mind at such a moment: 'Whatever you do, don't react, Alastair. If this is what you think it is – and it can't be anything else, can it? – it is highly confidential. Play it cool. Just finish your dessert, excuse yourself, and go outside to tell Alice she is about to become a Lady.'

You never consider yourself worthy of such an honour, but I thought I had missed out, because recipients tend to be told of their good fortune about six weeks before an official announcement, which, in this case, would come on New Year's Eve.